

Zerado – Naming Rationale

Locked in ratification round 1. The name goes in the headline, the browser tab, the logo, the binary, the domain, and the command people type.

What the word means

Zerado is Portuguese. Applied to a game it means **beaten — finished, cleared, 100%’d**. A player says “*zerei*” the way an English speaker says “*I finished it*”, except it carries more: not merely reaching the credits but having **closed the thing out**.

The origin is the part that matters here. It comes from **arcade cabinets** — the score counter running past its last digit and rolling back to zero. You had beaten the machine so thoroughly that its own display gave up. The word is not a metaphor borrowed from the eighties; it is **literally an artifact of the eighties**, minted by hardware that no longer exists.

That is why the identity is built on it rather than merely citing it. A counter rolling to zero is the mark (see `brand-manual.md` §3). The name is not decoration on top of the design — it *is* the design’s argument.

Why it won

1. Personality

The alternatives described a feature. This one describes **a feeling a player already has a word for**. It is short, it is spoken, and it is not a compound of two English nouns that a hundred other tools have already compounded.

2. The origin is the product

Zerado tracks a library and asks what you should play tonight. Its emotional payload is the moment a game moves into the *finished* column. The name is that moment. No other candidate had a story that resolved into the product's own core interaction.

3. Typing comfort – a real criterion for a terminal tool

This is a program people invoke by hand, many times a day. That makes the keyboard a design surface.

Property	Result
Length	6 letters
Shift key required	No
Digits or punctuation	None
Hand alternation	z-e-r-a-d-o alternates left/right cleanly
Ambiguous letters (l/1, o/0)	None
Reads as a command	<code>zerado sync</code> · <code>zerado tonight</code> · <code>zerado mark</code> <code>42 zerado</code>

`zerado sync` reads like a real command from a real tool — the same shape as `git push` or `brew update`. That was the test, and it passed.

The runners-up – recorded honestly

Two other names reached the final round. Neither was rejected for being bad.

`gigawatt`

For: an unambiguous *Back to the Future* citation, instantly legible to the target audience, easy for English speakers to say and spell.

Against: it is a **borrowed** eighties reference rather than an **owned** one — a quotation from a film, not a word from the domain. It says nothing about games, libraries, or finishing anything. It also invites a licensing conversation nobody wants, and "1.21 gigawatts" is a joke the internet has already used to exhaustion.

backlit

For: genuinely good English. Evokes a CRT, a keyboard, a screen in a dark room. Short, typeable, pronounceable, and quietly on-theme.

Against: it is **atmosphere without meaning**. It describes the lighting of the room the product runs in, not the thing the product does. It is also a common adjective in consumer electronics, which makes it weak to own and weak to search. And it has no second life as a verb or a status.

Why zerado beat both: it is the only candidate that is simultaneously the product's *name*, the product's *core action*, and an *authentic eighties artifact*. The other two had one of those at most.

The risks we accepted

These were known before the decision and were **accepted, not overlooked**. They are recorded here so nobody re-litigates them later or is surprised by them.

1. English speakers cannot pronounce or guess it

An English speaker seeing zerado cold does not know whether it is *zeh-RAH-doo*, *ZEH-ra-do*, or *zuh-RAY-doh*, and cannot infer the meaning at all. This is a genuine cost at the top of the funnel.

Accepted because: the launch audience is small, technical, and reads before it clicks. The landing page has room to explain the word once, in a clause, at the moment it first appears — which the ratified copy plan does.

Mitigation, and it is real: the page must **never** use the word as if it were self-evident. First contact always carries the gloss.

Reference pronunciation: **zeh-RAH-doo** (Brazilian Portuguese).

2. It collides with its own in-app status

The product is called Zerado, and marking a game *zerado* is a thing you do inside it. `zerado mark 42 zerado` is a real command.

Accepted because this is a feature, not a defect. A tool named after the act it exists to enable is a tool whose name explains itself the moment you use it. The landing page turns the collision into the payoff line rather than hiding it.

The one rule that keeps it from becoming confusing: the product is always **Zerado** (capitalised) and the status is always **zerado** (lowercase, and in prose, italicised on first use). See the casing convention below.

3. It is a common Portuguese word, so it is hard to search for

“zerado” returns bank balances at zero, reset counters, football scores, and general Portuguese usage. SEO for the bare term is effectively unwinnable in Portuguese-speaking markets.

Accepted because: the domain is `zerado.app`, which is exact-match and unambiguous; the launch channel is direct and community-led, not search; and the useful long-tail queries are compound anyway — “*zerado game tracker*”, “*zerado terminal*”, “*zerado backlog*” — where there is no competition at all.

Consequence for the site: the page must always pair the name with a qualifier in titles and metadata — “**Zerado — terminal game library**”, never a bare “Zerado”.

Collision check

Recorded from the naming round:

Checked for	Result
An existing game named Zerado	None found
An existing game tracker / backlog tool named Zerado	None found
A relevant trademark in the software or games class	None found
The domain <code>zerado.app</code>	Available and verified resolving
The repository <code>github.com/JustCode-CruzAlex/Zerado</code>	Verified public, HTTP 200 anonymously

Stated plainly, because it matters: this was a *conflict scan*, not a legal clearance. It is enough to proceed with a landing page and a public repository. It is **not** a registrability opinion, and it should not be treated as one. Before the name carries revenue — which, under the affiliate model, is the moment the first commission lands — it needs a real trademark search by someone qualified to give that opinion, in the classes and territories that will actually matter.

Casing convention – settled

This has three answers because there are three different objects. Getting them confused is the single most likely way to make the name read as sloppy.

Context	Form	Example
The product , in prose and titles	<code>Zerado</code>	“Zerado reads your Steam library.”

Context	Form	Example
The command , the binary, the domain, any code	zerado	zerado sync · zerado.app
The status inside the product, in prose	zerado , italic on first use	"Six games are <i>zerado</i> this year."
The status in the interface	ZERADO	the state chip, the filter, the column
The wordmark	ZERADO	the logotype only — see below

On the wordmark being uppercase

The logotype is drawn as **ZERADO** in constructed geometric capitals. This does **not** license uppercase in prose. A logotype is a drawn object with its own rules; it is not an instruction about how to write the word.

Two reasons it is capitals:

1. **Period correctness.** Wide, tightly-drawn, generously tracked capitals are the eighties corporate-future register — the DeLorean's own logotype, the Knight Industries badge, every dashboard readout of the era. Lowercase would read as 2016 startup, not 1984 machine.
2. **Construction.** The wordmark is built from the same rounded-rectangle skeleton as the mark, and the final **O** of **ZERADO** is geometrically the same shape as the mark itself. That rhyme only works in capitals, and it is what makes the lockup read as one designed system rather than an icon placed next to some type.

Never

- **ZeRaDo** , **zeraD0** , or any camel/stylised casing.
- **Zerado.app** — the domain is lowercase, always.
- Writing the product as **zerado** in prose, or the command as **Zerado** in a code block. The distinction is the whole mechanism that stops the name/status collision from becoming ambiguity.

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